

(2020), a collection of fiction and essays around South Asian food, which also came about from the work being done on the project.

Many of the essays in *Forgotten Foods* were meant to appear on the digital news website Scroll as a regular series but, as with so many other things, Covid-19 played spoiler and the full plan never materialised. Happily, all the pieces are now gathered in this book. The writings came together along with other projects including videos and experimental performances and, at the end of the preface there are QR codes through which these can be viewed.

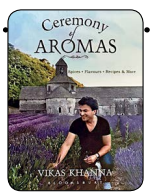
Dipping into the book, you immediately know that this volume will elbow itself into place on your cookbook and general food writing bookshelves, right next to the Madhur Jaffreys and Sameen Rushdies in the *desi* cluster. As is explained at the beginning, the book is divided into four sections: 'Memories'—family histories and memoir; 'Identities in Flux'—where culinary cultures are traced; 'Survival and Revival'—where people record the preserving and re-hydrating of old, sometimes almost extinct recipes; and 'A Dish in Time'—which explores particularities of regional cuisines. As indicated earlier, recipes appear metronomically, accompanying each piece of writing.

The book starts with a long memoir by Muneeza Shamsie where the well-known Karachi writer recounts the rich culinary history from both sides of her family and from both sides of the still tender and porous new border between India and Pakistan. Muneeza's clear writing (and memory) creates a startling picture of how upper-class Muslims in north India (and later south Pakistan) worshipped their extremely sophisticated and catholic taste-buds, from traditional Rampur recipes to European food to Indian-Angrezi *khana*. In Siobhan Lambert-Hurley's essay 'You are What you Eat', the inseparable link between food and laughter comes through as she describes the shuddering taboos carried by aristocratic Muslim ladies as they made their way westward on British ships, on some trips navigating the storms and whirlpools of the non-halal catering on-board (forcing them, one imagines like their vegetarian Hindu co-passengers, into eating only boiled vegetables); on others, for instance to Mecca, carrying a whole menagerie of food that could be slaughtered on the deck while protecting their own ghee so that they didn't have to eat Mecca Sharif's stinking ghee. Taking off from pieces such as these, the book moves through different classes and across regions, offering up a complex menu of food-writing.

This volume follows *Desi Delicacies* (2020), a collection of fiction and essays around South Asian food

The deadline for this review precluded this writer from attempting to test-drive any of the many recipes, but this is something to which I look forward. ■

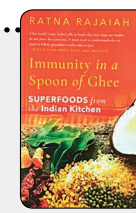
–Ruchir Joshi



CEREMONY OF AROMAS
Spices, Flavours, Recipes & More
by Vikas Khanna
BLOOMSBURY | **₹2,499; 390** pages

Everyone's favourite good-looking chef Vikas Khanna is back with another book. Although his last one—*Sacred Foods of India*—may be a difficult act to follow. That one was touted as the first 'phygital' (physical and digital) cookbook in the world, with its own NFT, and retailed at $50,000 for the sandalwood cover version and $20,000 for the one made with maple and walnut wood. Rather more affordable, *Ceremony of Aromas* from the chef fondly known as '*masala chor*' ('spice thief') has spices taking centre stage, with recipe sections devoted to cardamom, clove, etc.

All talk in our post-Covid world is of superfoods and that one magical fix for all our ills. Better still if it's a time-honoured cure. The best part about Ratna Rajaiah's book is that it's not a dry catalogue of superfoods but actually delves into each in detail, from the 'Rama-Lakshmana' of immunity that are turmeric and ginger, to ghee, one of the first foods given to a new mother and her infant. Oils, nuts, dry fruits...all get their due in this book.



IMMUNITY IN A SPOON OF GHEE: Superfoods from the Indian Kitchen
by Ratna Rajaiah
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 392 pages



THE INDIA COOKBOOK
From the Tables of My Friends
Selected & Edited by Sunita Kohli
ALEPH | **₹699; 288** pages

If you ever had the desire to know what goes into Subhalakshmi and Amjad Ali Khan's Chicken Korma, William Dalrymple's Tiger Prawns or Sharmila Tagore's Mutton Kebabs, it's all here. As India's foremost interior designer, Sunita Kohli keeps interesting—and august—company. But beneath the snob value of these fine tables is a serious cookbook, with recipes representative of regional Indian flavours.